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Submitter Information

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General Comment

Dear President Trump, National Science Foundation, and AI Action Plan team,

I urge the President and administration to consider the dangers of advanced artificial intelligence (AI), particularly autonomous AI agents and artificial general intelligence (AGI). I am not confident that they will, or even could, be used as trustworthy tools for the benefit of people.

If AGI were developed as many experts predict, and it could really do all of the intellectual work a human being could do, as current tech corporations hope to achieve, then I think this would be a disaster for mankind. It would be a disaster even if it was developed in a free democratic country, although perhaps worse if it was developed in an authoritarian country. The most obvious reason is that it would put hundreds of millions of people out of work. The second obvious reason is that the electricity and equipment required to support these new systems would cause an immense drain on natural resources needed by human beings and other living systems.

A potentially worse reason is that an AGI would hypothetically be able to copy and improve itself, somewhat analogous to a virus. This would be a threat unlike any which humanity has ever faced, although comparable in some ways to the nuclear arms race during the Cold War. It would not be just an issue of America competing with other nations, but the human race as a whole competing with entities which could surpass our own abilities. The AGI would not have to be consciously malevolent like in a science fiction movie. Natural entities such as viruses and hurricanes, and artificial ones such as toxic pollutants, cause immense harm worldwide despite not having any consciousness or intention at all. Eliezer Yudkowsky, who dedicated his life to studying these issues, says, "Many researchers steeped in these issues, including myself, expect that the most likely result of building a superhumanly smart AI, under anything remotely like the current circumstances, is that literally everyone on Earth will die. Not as in 'maybe possibly some remote chance,' but as in 'that is the obvious thing that would happen.'"

Fortunately, current AI systems cannot do these things. I hope that they never can, because I want human beings to remain in charge of our own future. But even current systems which are called AI, such as ChatGPT, are already causing great harm. Many of them have been trained by unethically, and probably illegally, harvesting intellectual property from the Internet to be processed for use as source material. Generative AI art programs are already putting artists and graphic designers out of work. Artificial intelligence software is already being used by tyrannical governments to control their citizens. Chatbots are already being used by students to avoid having to learn how to write clearly, thoughtfully, and articulately. I agree with Karl Sharro that "Humans doing the hard jobs on minimum wage while the robots write poetry and paint is not the future I wanted" – but it is the direction in which we are currently headed.

Those with large financial stakes in AI would like to see loosened regulations and increased government support – as any business leaders would like for their own company. But I think we need sensible safety regulation, increased research on safety, and increased cooperation with other countries on nonproliferation of dangerous systems. At the very least, giant software corporations should no longer be able to claim that they can take everyone else's work as "fair use" for their own products. Thank you very much for your consideration.

Sincerely,

Dr. John J. Dziak

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